



I'M NOT SURE I AGREE WITH YOU ONE HUNDRED PERCENT ON YOUR POLICE WORK THERE, LOU

FARGO / 1996

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Crime drama, comedy

DIRECTORS

Joel Coen, Ethan Coen

WRITERS

Joel Coen, Ethan Coen

STARS

William H. Macy, Frances McDormand, Steve Buscemi, Peter Stormare

BEFORE

1984 The Coens' first feature, *Blood Simple*, is a film noir in which ordinary folk are led to destruction by their own greed.

AFTER

2013 Another winter's tale, the Coens' *Inside Llewyn Davis* is the tale of a down-on-his-luck songwriter in New York.

2014 In David Zellner's *Kumiko, the Treasure Hunter*, a Japanese woman goes in search of treasure in Minnesota after watching *Fargo*, believing it to be real.



Fargo is a tragic farce that plays out at the slow, steady pace of a glacier. It begins with a car salesman named Jerry Lundegaard (William H. Macy), who desperately needs money to save himself from bankruptcy. Jerry hires grizzled goons Showalter (Steve Buscemi) and Grimsrud (Peter Stormare) to kidnap his wife (Kristin Rudrüd) and promises to split the ransom with the pair once the job is done. It's a simple plan, but, as with most things in Jerry's life, it goes horribly wrong.

Jerry's crime plays out against the blinding white wilderness of winter in Minnesota and North

Dakota, in the small towns of Fargo and Brainerd, and on the bleak highway that connects them. During the course of the kidnapping, Grimsrud accidentally kills a carful of people, and he and Showalter soon find that it is hard to dispose of corpses in weather so cold that graves cannot be dug and flesh does not rot. Grimsrud hits on a novel solution to this problem in the movie's audacious final act, but not before Brainerd's

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